



SRI LANKA

Capital city: Colombo
Area: 25,332 sq miles (65,610 sq km)
Population: 19,100,000
Official language: Sinhala, Tamil
Major religions: Buddhist 69%, Hindu 15%, Christian 8%, Muslim 8%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Sri Lanka rupee
Adult literacy rate: 92%
Life expectancy: 74 years
People per doctor: 2,319
Televisions: 92 per 1,000 people



SAPPHIRE BLUE

Sri Lanka is known for its gemstones, particularly those from Ratnapura, the "City of Gems." Sapphires, rubies, topazes, amethysts, and garnets are all found in the rocks nearby. Many are made into superb jewelry or exported abroad.

Tea seeds are first sown in a nursery bed and then the young plants are transplanted to a field.



TEA GROWING

Tea is grown mainly on large plantations in the central highlands. The cooler climate makes the tea grow slowly, adding to its flavor. Only the youngest, most tender leaves are harvested, and then processed quickly to retain quality. Tea makes up about a third of the island's exports. Recently, the tea industry has suffered fierce competition from countries producing cheaper, lower quality tea.

SRI LANKA

SRI LANKA IS A TEARDROP-SHAPED island that lies off the southeastern coast of India. It is known for its tropical, palm-fringed beaches, rugged mountains, and varied wildlife, which attract thousands of tourists. In recent years, Sri Lanka and its tourist industry have been badly hit by fighting between the Sinhalese people and the minority Tamil group, which wants an independent state. Agriculture is important to Sri Lanka. Tea, rubber, and coconuts are grown on large plantations and are the main export crops. Rice is the main food crop.

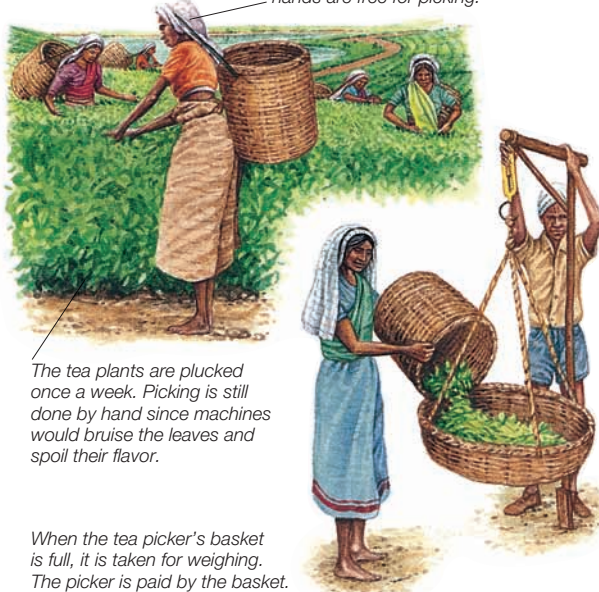


Many Tamil women are employed as tea pickers.

THE TAMILS

Tensions between the Sinhalese government and the Tamils erupted into civil war between 1983 and 2002. The Tamils object to the domination of the island by the Sinhalese and are demanding their own independent state in the north. Tamils, who are mostly Hindu, make up about 20 percent of the population. The mainly Buddhist Sinhalese form the majority, accounting for about 75 percent.

The women hang the baskets from their heads, so that both hands are free for picking.



The tea plants are plucked once a week. Picking is still done by hand since machines would bruise the leaves and spoil their flavor.

When the tea picker's basket is full, it is taken for weighing. The picker is paid by the basket.



THE SACRED TOOTH

The most important Buddhist festival in Sri Lanka takes place in Kandy in August. A beautifully decorated elephant parades through the streets, carrying a gold casket containing the sacred tooth of the Buddha. For the rest of the year, the tooth is kept in the Temple of the Tooth. It is said that the tooth was snatched from the Buddha's funeral pyre (fire) in 543 BC.



BEAUTIFUL BEACHES

Tourism has become one of Sri Lanka's most important industries. The country is well known for its beautiful sandy beaches, especially on the south and southwest coasts, and its Buddhist temples and monuments farther inland, particularly the ancient city of Kandy. However, the effects of the civil war and the Indian Ocean tsunami in 2004 have recently kept tourists away.



The leaves are then fermented and dried to produce the final product.

Find out more

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